

The Jack of ALL

Multi-Function Devices are the latest in space saving techniques, both for home as well as office users. We pit 13 of them against each other to see which one best suits your needs

One peripheral commodity that is rapidly gaining popularity, amongst manufacturers and target audience alike, is the multi-function device (MFD). When introduced in the market a few years ago, they failed to entice users, given their mediocre performance and unjustifiable price. But that was long ago. The new crop of MFD is on par, if not better, than their stand-alone counterparts. This acceleration in acceptance is a result of something as elementary as lack of space. As the metropolitan cities spill out in every direction, offices are trying to squeeze in as much productivity per square inch as technologically possible—and MFDs promise just that.

But therein lies the paradox, though MFDs seem ideal for workspaces, manufacturers think otherwise. Most have introduced MFDs for SoHo, with the price being more an area for concern, than performance. The low-end band plays to the home-user's tune—all basic functions of printing, copying and scanning are seen to, and in some cases, even faxing. This Consumer category is the site for some aggressive pricing, with the lowest MFD costing just around Rs 5,000.

Not that the commercial segment is completely ignored. High-end MFDs are feature-rich, offer better performance and also come with frills such direct printing from flash cards, full-fledged faxing and extra paper handling capacity. This 'Prosumer' category is all about performance and lacing. The price range for a prosumer MFD starts around Rs 10,000, and can go up to Rs 35,000. The highest level of MFDs is the Enterprise level devices which cost in excess of Rs 1,00,000.

The Consumer and Prosumer categories use the thermal or piezoelectric inkjet technology to offer colour printouts. However, in an office environment, the bulk printing is always in black text, making the inkjet a technology too expensive to waste. To counter this, a new breed of MFDs based on Laser technology has also been introduced, and is priced above Rs 40,000. We got just three such MFDs, but since they were placed in different price bracket, we decided against a direct comparison between them.

SANKET NAIK
sanket_naik@thinkdigit.com

SHIJU THOMAS
shiju_thomas@thinkdigit.com